ECHO



photo by Alasdair McLellan



photo by Alasdair McLellan

ADELE: THEN & NOW

Editor: Sally Li

Authors: Tom Lamont, Abby Aguirre

Photographers: Alasdair McLellan, Malte Christians, Giulio Marcocchi, Jeff Kravitz, Rune Hellestad, Simon Emmett, Will Heath, Raven B. Varona

Adele's work exists at the intersection of intimacy and scale. Her voice is powerful, but its resonance comes from emotional precision rather than spectacle. Across her career, she has resisted constant reinvention, allowing her music and public presence to evolve slowly through lived experience. She sings and speaks with disarming honesty, balancing vulnerability with restraint. In a culture drawn to excess and performance, Adele's consistency and self awareness feel grounding and enduring.

This issue brings together two moments from the same voice, separated by time. One article captures Adele at the edge of recognition, candid and unguarded before expectation settles in. The other looks back from a place of success, reflection, and self knowledge. Read side by side, these pieces reveal both change and continuity. Her voice has grown in confidence and control, but its emotional clarity remains unchanged. This issue is less interested in reinvention than in presence, tracing how a voice carries forward, shaped by experience, yet still unmistakably its own.

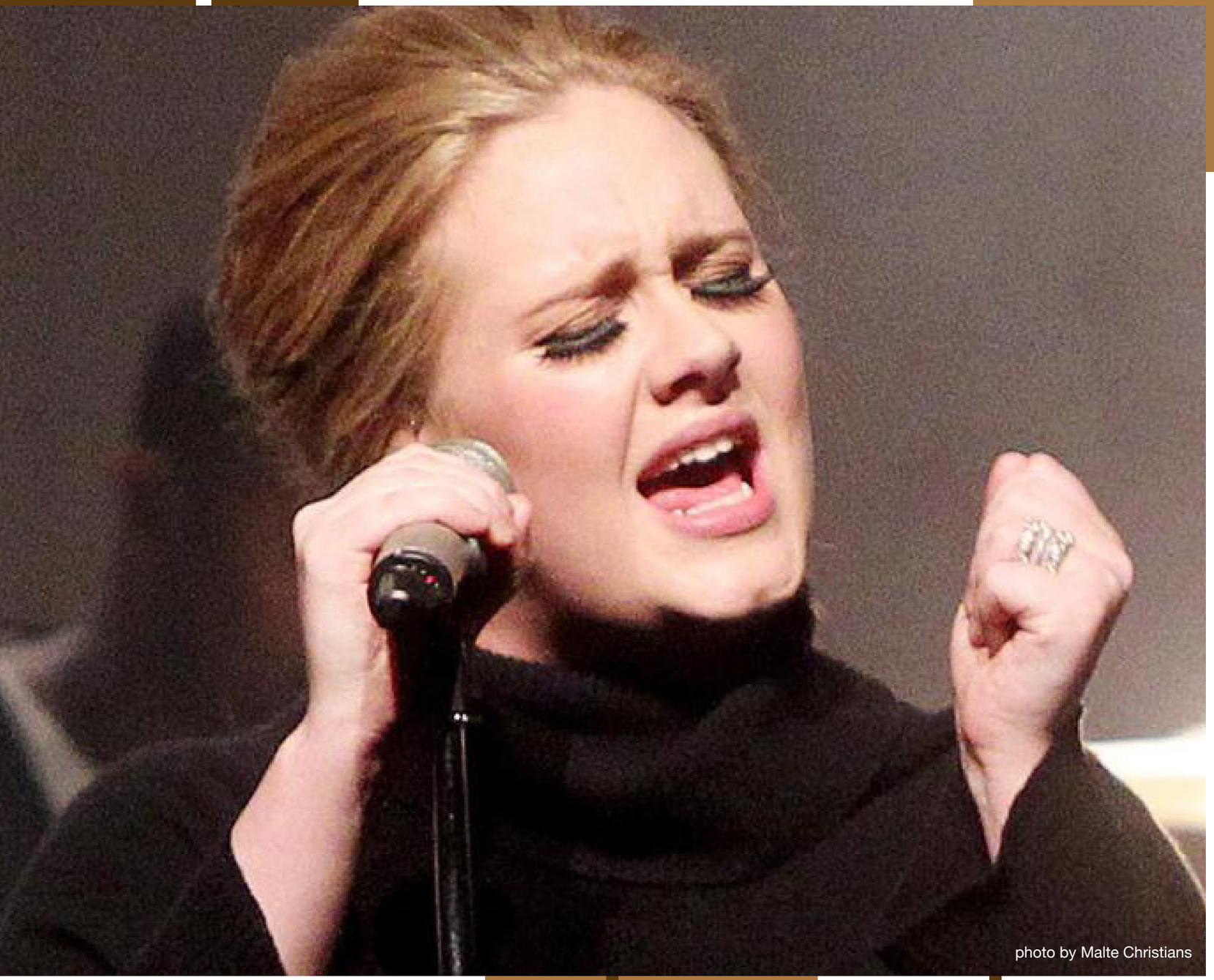


photo by Malte Christians

Adele: the girl with the mighty mouth

By Tom Lamont

As the London singer conquers both Britain and America with a smash-hit No 1 album, we meet a superstar in the making.

It is a gusty Saturday in New York in late February, and Adele is not yet a very big deal. The 22-year-old singer from London, Adele Adkins in full, can drift into the lobby of a posh hotel in Manhattan and remain ignored, mostly, while other guests gather at the windows to watch the wind.

It's chaos outside. "Windy," says Adele, approaching from behind, offering about the last instance of understatement I will hear from her over the next few days. It's a distinctive voice, hard cockney in Greenwich Village, but nobody turns from the window. It's that sort of hotel, accustomed to celebrity of varying degrees, and anyway Adele is not yet a very big deal in America because her new album, 21, isn't out for another week. Nobody's sure if it will make the same splash as her first, 19, so she has a week of hard promotion ahead: breakfast telly, radio interviews, an appearance on The Late Show with David Letterman, the country's most iconic talk show.

Wrapped warm in a camel-coloured jumper, red hair pulled back and pinned, she makes herself comfy on a lobby sofa and starts talking. "… always trying to jazz it up in first class by putting it on a plate, but it don't work, just give us chicken tikka masala." She orders hot water and honey

from a passing waiter, explaining: “My voice went recently, never happened before, off like a tap.” She’s been banned from all the good stuff since, like caffeine, cigarettes, alcohol in fun quantities. “I had to sit in silence for nine days, chalkboard around my neck. Like an old-school mime. Like a kid in the naughty corner. Like a Victorian mute.”

Losing her voice must have been devastating.

It’s difficult not to be charmed, in a hurry, by someone as diverted by the pedestrian as Adele. In the foreground Adele is swearing like a squaddie, doing impressions, talking about… well, you’re never quite sure where she’ll go.

At live shows, Adele’s on-stage banter has become justifiably famous, and most of it is like this, generous and filthy, broken up by bawdy laughter and what-am-I-likes. Four years on and she can still catch you by surprise: that wartime-landlady chitchat, then suddenly the dreadnought vocal. “I get so nervous on stage I can’t help but talk. I try. I try telling my brain: stop sending words to the mouth. But I get nervous and turn into my grandma. Behind the eyes it’s pure fear. I find it difficult to believe I’m going to be able to deliver.”

A few days earlier, back in London, Adele had definitely delivered. One of a handful of artists booked to sing live at the 2011 Brits, she took to the stage at the O2 Arena and sang the closing track from 21. On the record the song, “Someone Like You”, is a simple but affecting ballad about heartbreak. Sung live at the Brits, the only accompaniment a piano, it altered a career.

Whoops and shouts from 16,000 in the upper tiers stopped as soon as she got going; on the


photo by Giulio Marcocchi


photo by Jeff Kravitz

arena floor even the tables of fizzed-up music execs fell quiet as Adele – now with sad and doleful eyes, now sneering, now fighting back tears – hauled everybody through the mangle of a break-up. It was an astonishing performance, and at the song’s end she turned away from the microphone, biting her thumb, trying not to cry in the face of a standing ovation. Glitter fell from the eaves, making her exposed shoulders sparkle.

“Shat myself,” says Adele in the hotel lobby. “I was on in between Take That and Rihanna, the biggest productions of the night. All day I was thinking, this is gonna be a disaster.”

By midweek the record was catching up with a Lady Gaga single at No 1. There are murmurs that the Brits was the night Adele’s star was born.

But she is not there yet. As if to emphasise the fact, a bona fide superstar cuts through the lobby. I’m first aware of it when Adele widens her eyes and says “porter, porter”. It’s Natalie Portman, a week before the Oscars and very pregnant, sweeping through the room and out into the blistering wind. Adele looks quite star-struck. “Do



photo by Rune Hellestad

you ever get that, the heart flutter? I turn into a wreck. Go all light-headed."

That won't happen. Before dawn she'll be woken by her manager who'll tell her that she's beaten Gaga and gone to No 1 in the UK for the first time in her career. She'll cry and call her mum. Then she'll find out that "Rolling in the Deep" has moved up to No 4; that 21 has held fast at No 1 in the album chart, and that 19 has reached No 4. She'll end the day with two albums and two singles in the top five, the first time such a thing has happened for 50 years.

Assume, by the way, that Adele is swearing at all times. Between words, between syllables, she effs as easily as she laughs. "Can somebody get me a facking screwdriver? I'm going for the facking wiring. Doing my facking 'ead in."

We are backstage at the Ed Sullivan theatre in Times Square, where The Late Show with David Letterman is filmed. Half a dozen people are crammed into Adele's small dressing room. "But you can't complain about your dressing room," sighs Adele, "or you look like Celine Dion."

When we'd spoken in the hotel she'd made repeated reference to her team, her gang. They were the ones who kept her sane, she said. Here they all are: manager, UK and US publicists, hairdresser, make-up guy, someone they've started calling "Colonel Sanders" because he's the only one who knows how to mix hot water and honey the way Adele likes it.

It is two days after our interview in the lobby, a day after her chart triumph. Like the weather-battered city, Adele's team seem dazed by the last 48 hours. One of her publicists is low in a chair, wrestling a hangover. "I know he was out 'til 6am," says Adele, "cos he facking Tweeted it."

Soon after this, a publicist approaches and asks me if I've got a delete button in my brain.

With half an eye on the football Adele's manager explains what's been happening at home. "On Thursday we were 20,000 sales behind Gaga. Friday, 125 behind." In the end, Adele won by 30,000 copies. As for the achievement of having two records in the top five of both the UK single and album charts, "the last act to do that were the Beatles". "Sometimes the stars align for you."

It all started for Adele on TV, with a Beatle. Some of her early songs caught the attention of producers on Later… with Jools Holland in summer 2007, and without a release to her name she was plopped on an episode to sing next to Paul McCartney. A buzz picked up around her: killer voice, that cherubic face and unapologetic size-14-ness, her oozy sass.

She grew up in London (first north in Tottenham, then south in Lambeth) the only child of an 18-year-old mother, Penny. Penny took Adele to her first gig at toddler age – the Cure at Finsbury Park – seeding an obsession with pop music that never went away. At school she faked an eye injury to justify wearing a sequinned eye-patch in homage to Gabrielle. Later, "I was so in love with Mike Skinner I wrote him a letter."

In the late 90s she was passing through an American rock phase when she noticed an Etta James record. Somewhere between a few more obsessions she popped Etta James into the CD player, and thought: Oh, I can do that.

Guitarist Ben is present today, tuning up on the Letterman set. Most of Adele's gang joined her early. She met one of the publicists as a teenager in a club. She signed with manager Dickins because he made her laugh, "literally stomach cramps the day after".

For years Adele's been asked about who she's going out with, who her wounded love songs are about. "Who cares?" she says. "Nobody famous, just old boyfriends. I don't date celebrities. I ain't facking Taylor Swift, dyouknowhatImean?"

The Brits gig has returned focus to what Adele was really about. Those room-silencing pipes.

When I first saw her perform in 2007, in the sweaty and densely packed Scala in King's Cross, she tamed a belligerent room in an instant. "I love hearing my audience breathe," says Adele.

When Adele appeared on Saturday Night Live in 2008, her dressing-room stablemate was Sarah Palin. Within hours of broadcast, 19 sold an extra 10,000 copies. Two big US tours followed, and at the 2009 Grammys she was the surprise recipient of two awards.

Today's Letterman appearance is meant to remind a nation about that Grammy-worthy vocal. "When I hear artists say, 'Performing is what I'm meant to do', I think, Whaaaat? This ain't what you're meant to do."

Everybody stares anxiously at the dressing-room TV as Adele, on screen, is introduced by David Letterman. "Don't say shit, Adele!" shouts Dickins. The song starts. The danger lyric comes, goes. She doesn't say shit. "Force of nature, this girl," he says.

The song crescendoes, ends, and the cheers of the crowd suggest it went well. Later, when Letterman and the audience have gone home, Adele plays a small gig in the Ed Sullivan theatre. Both her single and her album hold fast at No 1 in the UK charts the following week.

Always a big deal in Norway; now a big deal in the UK; soon a big deal in the US. But, at the tipping point, she is still a singer who will dedicate a song to her pet dog. "Sorry," says Adele, "there are children in the room." She takes a flustered slug of honey and water. "I can just see it in the papers tomorrow." She mimes zipping up her mouth with her fingers.

Adele
on the Other Side

By Abby Aguirre



photo by Simon Emmett



photo by Will Heath

On my way to Heart & Hustle, a private gym in West Hollywood, where I will be joining Adele for her Monday morning workout, I get the distinct feeling that the Queen of Hearts is about to put me through my paces.

It's inevitable to some degree. Adele has been doing rigorous weight-lifting and circuit-training sessions every day for three years and counting. It is also true that if the whole world went nuts at the first sight of your significant weight loss, and aired a lot of uninformed theories and loud opinions about your significant weight loss, one way to set the record straight and reclaim the narrative would be to put a journalist to absolute shame at your gym.

When she arrives, breezing through the back door in head-to-toe spandex, my fate is clear. Adele is not merely fit. She's a brick house, with the kind of muscle definition that's visible through leggings. Heart & Hustle is a no-frills establishment, owned by two guys from New York and Philly, and one of them, Gregg Miele, is here to lead our workout. Within minutes, Adele is going to town on an elliptical, and I'm just a few feet away, swishing around on another machine, already short of breath.

She starts peppering me with questions, cutting to the quick in that uniquely disarming way that compels you to do the same. When this is sustained for any period of time, it results in a turbo-speed confessional that can only be conveyed with a timeline.

A few minutes in, Adele mentions that she has a bad back. I tell her that I have two slipped discs. We establish that she has the same slipped discs (L5 and L6). While going hard on the elliptical, Adele remarks, "I'm always a bit hungover on Monday morning." Lockdown turned me into a seven-nights-a-week wine drinker, I tell her. She nods and says: "It got earlier and earlier, the drinking."

Adele says that she has probably spent more time with Miele in the last three years than anyone else. “All these other people have come out saying that they trained me,” she says. “Fuckin’ weirdos. I’ve never met them in my life!”

I ask if COVID took an emotional toll. Adele responds that much of the emotional stuff her friends went through, she’d gone through the year before, in the middle of her divorce. (Adele was married to the charity executive Simon Konecki for two years. They have a nine-year-old son, Angelo.) “Everyone had to face a lot of their demons, because they had so much time on their hands with nothing to distract them,” she says. “They had to face themselves in isolation. Whereas I did that the year before.”

Back on the subject of alcohol and lockdown. “My first emergency run at the grocery store was for Whispering Angel and ketchup,” Adele says, referring to her favorite rosé. “Whispering Angel turned me into a barking dog. It did not make me whisper.”

It goes on like this for an hour, as Adele proceeds through every weight machine and I wilt in the manner of someone who hasn’t seen the inside of a gym since 2016. She spent many pandemic days and nights here, working out while a movie played on the TV.

Adele’s home in Beverly Hills looks a lot like an English cottage, except that it’s somewhere on the order of 6,500 square feet. I meet her there after our workout and we settle into sofa chairs in her very English garden. She is wearing what look to be cashmere pants and an elegant white button-up, only one of whose buttons is buttoned, revealing a slim hourglass figure and braless décolletage.

Adele takes pains to protect her voice, particularly since she underwent surgery in 2011 to stop a vocal-cord hemorrhage. So it seems significant that when I ask what events led up to her Year of Anxiety, she begins with two shows she had to cancel in the summer of 2017. “I think once my voice rests it doesn’t want to come back for a while,” she says. “I think that’s what happened. The momentum went.” The shows were at Wembley Stadium, and canceling them meant canceling on 200,000 people. “I’m not allowed to perform if I’m not well anymore, because obviously I had surgery years ago. So there was no even pushing through it. I was devastated.”

“Then I hit my Saturn return,” Adele says, flipping up her left wrist to show me a tattoo. It’s Saturn, the planet, with a drawing of L.A. in the middle. “It’s where I lost the plot.” It takes 27 to 32 years for Saturn to fully orbit around the sun and return to the position it was in when you were born, Adele explains. “When that comes, it can rock your life,” she says. “It shakes you up a bit: Who am I? What do I want to do? What makes me truly happy? All those things.”

She does not blame her divorce on her Saturn return, but that was one result of it. “I was just going through the motions and I wasn’t happy,” she says. “Neither of us did anything wrong. Neither of us hurt each other or anything like that. It was just: I want my son to see me really love, and be loved. It’s really important to me.” She says she and Konecki were broken up for some time before they told people. (Adele filed for divorce in 2019.) “I’ve been on my journey to find my true happiness ever since.”

What has the process entailed? “Well, my therapist told me that I had to sit with my little seven-year-old self. Because she was left on her own. And I needed to go sit with her and really address how I felt when I was growing up. And issues with my dad. Which I’d been avoiding.” And what were those issues? “Not being sure if someone who is supposed to love you loves you, and doesn’t prioritize you in any capacity when you’re little. You assume it and get used to it. So



photo by Alasdair McLellan

my relationship with men in general, my entire life, has always been: You're going to hurt me, so I'll hurt you first. It's just toxic and prevents me from actually finding any happiness."



photo by Alasdair McLellan

"The gym became my time. I realized that when I was working out, I didn't have any anxiety. It was never about losing weight."

What helped Adele get her through her Year of Anxiety? "It was a lot of sound baths. It was a lot of meditation. It was a lot of therapy. And a lot of time spent on my own." The gym was key: "It became my time. I realized that when I was working out, I didn't have any anxiety. It was never about losing weight. I thought, If I can make my body physically strong, and I can feel that and see that, then maybe one day I can make my emotions and my mind physically strong." She started with her lower back and stomach: "I have a bad back and I had a C-section. So I had just nothing going on down there." (When I call Miele, her trainer, later, he confirms that the goal wasn't weight loss. "It was getting stronger, physically and mentally. She got really turned on to movement, and especially strength training. So turned on that she started doing double sessions.")

Progress was slow and far from linear. "I'd have a lovely night with my friends," she says, "and then I'd wake up like a tsunami was coming for me." As a Taurus, she likes to schedule things, so she found the unpredictability of her anxiety excruciating. "I remember sitting out there with two of my friends," she says, "and I was like, When will I stop feeling like this? And they were like, In time. And I was like, Yeah, but how much time? And one of them cried and was just like, I don't know. It's gonna be a ride. And it was."

One particular exchange stands out. "I told my friend, I feel like I'm on a steep mountain, trying to get up to the top. And she was like, You will get there. And you'll have a nice leisurely stroll down. And then there'll be another fucking mountain. And I'm like, I'm not even over this one yet. And she was like, That's just life." Adele flips up her right wrist to show me a tattoo of a mountain, which she got at the end of 2019.

Some of the most difficult moments involved Angelo. On the whole, Adele says, the divorce has gone as smoothly as a divorce can. Konecki lives across the street, in a house Adele bought for him, and they share custody. Even during the turbulent moments, Adele had faith that she was doing the right thing: "If I can reach the reason why I left, which was the pursuit of my own happiness, even though it made Angelo really unhappy, if I can find that happiness and he sees me in that happiness, then maybe I'll be able to forgive myself for it." But she couldn't prevent the pain she was causing him in the meantime. One day, when he was only six and a half: "He said to my face, Can you see me? And I was like, Uh, yeah. And he was like, Cause I can't see you. Well, my whole life fell apart in that moment. He knew I wasn't there." She decided to have regular conversations with Angelo about what was happening. "That's when I started sharing with him."

She also started going to the studio. She wrote a song for Angelo the day after he told her he couldn't see her. Over time, the album became a way of explaining things to him. "He has so many simple questions for me that I can't answer, because I don't know the answer. Like, Why can't we still live together? That's just not what people do when they get divorced. But why not? I'm like, I don't fucking know. That's not what society does. And: Why don't you love my dad anymore? And I'd be like, I do love your dad. I'm just not in love. I can't make that make sense to a nine-year-old."

For this and other reasons, the new album is different from her previous albums. "I realized that I was the problem," Adele says. "Cause all the other albums are like, You did this! You did that! Fuck you! Why can't you arrive for me? Then I was like: Oh, shit, I'm the running theme, actually. Maybe it's me!"



I ask if she revisited any iconic divorce albums in the process of writing hers, and Adele responds that she didn't know she was making a divorce album. She's not sure it is one, in fact. "He's not one of my exes. He's the dad of my child." If the new album is a divorce album, it's a different kind of divorce album. "It was more me divorcing myself," she says, exploding into a laugh. "Just being like, Bitch, fuckin' hot mess, get your fuckin' shit together!"

"It's sensitive for me, this record, just in how much I love it," Adele adds. "I always say that 21 doesn't belong to me anymore. Everyone else took it into their hearts so much. I'm not letting go of this one. This is my album. I want to share myself with everyone, but I don't think I'll ever let this one go."



photo by Raven B. Varona

"

So I hope I learn to get over myself
Stop trying to be somebody else
So we can love each other for free
Everybody wants something
You just want me

"

ADELE: THEN & NOW